SETUP GUIDE — V1.0.0

FlipBot Pro

Full Installation & Configuration Manual

Version 1.0.0 Node.js ≥ 18.0 Setup time ~20 minutes

APIs eBay · OpenAI · Facebook

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01 — PREREQUISITES

Before You Begin

Make sure you have all of these in place before starting.

✓ **Node.js v18 or later**

Download from **nodejs.org**. Verify with `node --version` in your terminal.

✓ **eBay Seller Account**

You need an active eBay seller account to post listings via the API. A basic personal account works for getting started.

✓ **Facebook Account with Marketplace access**

A personal Facebook account with Marketplace enabled in your region. Do not use a brand-new account — established accounts are far less likely to be flagged.

✓ **OpenAI Account**

Required for flaw detection and AI-generated listing copy. Sign up at **platform.openai.com**. Budget $5–$10/month for typical usage.

Install & Setup

Clone the repo, install dependencies, and run the setup wizard.

1 **Clone the repository**

Download the code to your machine.

```
git clone https://github.com/brodyautomates/flipbot-pro.git
cd flipbot-pro
```

2 **Install Node.js dependencies**

This installs Express, Playwright, the OpenAI SDK, and all other packages.

```
npm install
```

3 **Install the Playwright browser**

Playwright needs to download Chromium to automate Facebook Marketplace.

```
npx playwright install chromium
```

4 **Run the setup wizard**

This interactive wizard creates your `.env` file. Have your API keys ready (see Sections 3–5).

```
npm run setup
```

eBay Developer Keys

The eBay API is used for two things: searching sold comps and posting listings.

1 **Create an eBay Developer account**

Go to **developer.ebay.com** and sign in with your eBay account. Click "Get Started" and accept the developer agreement.

2 **Create a new application**

Navigate to **My Account → Application Access Keys**. Click **Create a Keyset**. Choose "Production" for live use (or "Sandbox" to test without real listings going live).

3 **Copy your three keys**

After creating the keyset, copy the **App ID (Client ID)**, **Cert ID (Client Secret)**, and **Dev ID**. You will need all three.

4 **Set your Redirect URI**

In your app settings, set a Redirect URI. This can be `https://localhost` for self-hosted setups. Copy the RuName (Redirect URI name) shown in the app settings.

⚠ SANDBOX VS PRODUCTION

Set `EBAY_SANDBOX=true` during initial setup to test listing creation without real items going live on eBay. Once confirmed working, switch to `false`.

.ENV VARIABLE	WHERE TO FIND IT
`EBAY_APP_ID`	App ID (Client ID) on your keyset page
`EBAY_CERT_ID`	Cert ID (Client Secret) on your keyset page
`EBAY_DEV_ID`	Dev ID — same on all keysets for your account
`EBAY_REDIRECT_URI`	RuName from your app's auth settings

04 — OPENAI API SETUP

OpenAI API Key

Used for GPT-4o image analysis (flaw detection) and generating listing copy.

1

Sign up or log in at platform.openai.com

Create an account if you don't have one. You'll need to add a credit card — there's no free tier for API access.

2

Create an API key

Navigate to **API Keys** in your account dashboard. Click **Create new secret key**. Copy it immediately — it won't be shown again.

3

Set a usage limit (recommended)

Under **Usage limits**, set a monthly hard limit of $20 while testing. This prevents runaway costs if the bot scans at high volume.

💡 EXPECTED COST

GPT-4o costs approximately $0.01–$0.03 per item scanned (image analysis + description generation). At 500 items/day, expect ~$5–$15/month in OpenAI costs.

Authenticating with Facebook

The bot uses your saved browser session to access Marketplace. This is a one-time setup.

1 **Run the login script**

This opens a visible browser window (not headless) so you can log in manually.

```
npm run login
```

2 **Log in to Facebook in the browser window**

Complete the login normally, including any 2FA if you have it enabled. Do *not* close the browser window manually.

3 **Press ENTER in the terminal**

Once you're logged in and can see your Facebook feed, go back to the terminal and press ENTER. Your session cookies are saved to `data/session/fb-session.json`.

⚠ SESSION EXPIRY

Facebook sessions typically last 30–90 days. If the bot logs "Session expired", run `npm run login` again. The session file is gitignored and stays local to your machine only.

Environment Variables

All bot behaviour is controlled through your `.env` file.

VARIABLE	DEFAULT	DESCRIPTION
`PORT`	3000	Port the dashboard runs on
`BOT_KEYWORDS`	bike,tools,electronics	Comma-separated list of Marketplace search terms
`BOT_MIN_MARGIN_PCT`	25	Minimum net margin % (after eBay fees) to flag as a match
`BOT_SCAN_INTERVAL_SEC`	300	Seconds between scan cycles (300 = every 5 minutes)
`BOT_MAX_DAILY_MESSAGES`	200	Hard cap on outgoing lowball messages per day
`FB_LOCATION`	dallas	City slug from the Marketplace URL (e.g., "los-angeles")
`FB_MAX_PRICE`	5000	Maximum listing price to scan
`FB_HEADLESS`	true	Set to `false` to watch the browser run (debugging)
`EBAY_SANDBOX`	false	Set to `true` during testing — no real listings posted
`PROXY_URL`	empty	Optional HTTP proxy for high-volume use

💡 **LOCATION SLUGS**

Find your city slug by going to Facebook Marketplace and searching. The URL will be something like `facebook.com/marketplace/dallas/search` — use the part after `/marketplace/`.

Starting FlipBot Pro

Once your .env is configured and Facebook is authenticated.

```
npm start
```

The terminal will show:

```
  ▄▄▄▄▄▄  FlipBot Pro
  ▄▄ ▄▄   v1.0.0

  Dashboard  →  http://localhost:3000
  Mode       →  Production
  Keywords   →  bike, tools, electronics
  Scan every →  300s
  Min margin →  25%
```

Open **http://localhost:3000** in your browser to see the live dashboard. The bot begins its first scan immediately.

💡 RUNNING IN THE BACKGROUND

To keep the bot running after you close the terminal, use a process manager like PM2:

```
npm install -g pm2
pm2 start server.js --name flipbot-pro
pm2 save
```

Reading the Dashboard

What each panel shows and how to interpret the data.

PANEL	WHAT IT SHOWS
Header Stats	Total items scanned this session, active eBay listings, estimated gross profit, total lowball messages sent
Live Activity Feed	Real-time log of every action the bot takes. Color-coded: green = match/posted, yellow = lowball/followup, red = skipped, gray = scan
P&L Table	Every item scanned with buy price, eBay comp, net margin %, and status. Green rows = above threshold (posted). Yellow = borderline. Red = skipped.
Margin Distribution	Bar chart showing how scanned items distribute across margin buckets
Lowball Engine	Counter of total messages sent today plus the last 10 sent messages with seller handles and response status
eBay Listings	Cards for every item the bot has posted to eBay this session. Click any card for the full AI-generated listing detail.

💡 PAUSE / RESUME

The PAUSE BOT button in the header freezes all bot activity — no new scans, no messages, no listings. The dashboard stays live and connected. Use this if you need to step away or investigate something.

Common Issues

Most problems are solved by one of the fixes below.

ERROR / SYMPTOM	FIX
"No Facebook session found"	Run `npm run login` and complete the login process
"Facebook session expired"	Run `npm run login` again to refresh the session
Bot finds listings but margin is always 0	Check your eBay App ID is correct and the API is returning results
eBay listing fails with "Invalid token"	Verify `EBAY_APP_ID` and `EBAY_CERT_ID` are correct in your .env
Dashboard shows "DISCONNECTED"	The server is not running. Run `npm start` first.
No listings found for keywords	Try broader keywords or change `FB_LOCATION` to a larger city
FB_HEADLESS=true but browser opens anyway	This is normal on first run — check `.env` value has no quotes around `true`